
THE KIRA METHOD

COMPLETE GUIDE

YOUR TRAVEL SAFETY · 47 COUNTRIES · WHAT THEY DON'T TELL YOU

TRAVEL SAFETY GUIDE



47 Countries · 8 Chapters · Instant Download

AIRPORTS · HOTELS · CRUISE SHIPS · RESTAURANTS · RESORTS

AIRPORT SECURITY

HOTEL SAFETY

CRUISE TIPS

FOOD TRAPS

MONEY SCAMS

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What I learned in 47 countries — before anyone told me.

I've traveled to 47 countries across six continents. Most of what I know, I learned the hard way — a fake taxi in Cairo, a two-bill trick in Rome, a hotel "upgrade" in Bali that cost me three extra days.

This guide isn't a list of things to be afraid of. It's the briefing I wish someone had given me before my first international trip. The specific mechanics. The exact phrases. The things that happen all the time that nobody talks about because they're embarrassing to admit.

The most common version of what happens to travelers isn't dramatic. It's a taxi that takes 40 minutes instead of 15, a restaurant bill that's \$22 more than it should be, a hotel room that turns out to be nothing like the photos. None of it ruins a trip. But knowing what's coming — and knowing exactly what to say — changes everything.

Read the chapter that applies to your next trip segment, before that segment. The taxi chapter is most useful on the plane. The hotel chapter at the airport. The restaurant chapter over breakfast on day one.

Travel smarter. Not harder.

— Kira

8 Chapters. Real Insider Intel.

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Airport & Arrival

The first 20 minutes after landing are when experienced thieves work. You're tired, overstimulated, and making a hundred small decisions. They make one: you.

01 The Baggage Belt Setup — Two People, One Target

This is not random. Thieves at baggage claim work in pairs. One stands near you and "accidentally" drops something — phone, boarding pass, sunglasses. The moment you look down to help, the second person grabs your carry-on from the floor. They're gone before you straighten up.

The fix: Your carry-on lives between your feet, not beside them. Keep your eyes on the belt. If someone drops something near you, don't move your feet. Let them pick it up themselves.

ROME FCO

BARCELONA BCN

BANGKOK

NAIROBI

02 The Arrivals Hall "Welcome" Desk

Just past customs, someone in a vest or uniform stands at a "Tourist Information" or "Hotel Transfers" desk. They look official. They are not. These are independent operators who charge 3–5× market rate for taxis and will often redirect you to a cousin's guesthouse.

The fix: Walk past every desk in the arrivals hall. Official tourist information is always run by the airport or local government and is signposted before customs, not after. Book transfers before you land.

03

Italy: Validate Your Train Ticket or Pay \$55+

This catches tens of thousands of tourists every year. In Italy, you must validate (stamp) your train ticket in a small yellow or green machine on the platform before you board — even if you bought it online and printed it. On regional trains, an unvalidated ticket = no ticket. Inspectors board at random stops. The fine is \$55–\$220 (€50–€200), not negotiable, and they pull you off the train.

The fix: QR code tickets from the app are auto-validated. Paper tickets are not. Stamp before the platform. Every time.

ITALY — ALL REGIONAL TRAINS

04

Airport Currency Exchange — The Worst Rate in the Building

Airport currency counters offer rates 8–15% worse than the real rate. The signs say "No Commission" because all the profit is in the spread. Exchanging \$200 at the airport costs you \$16–\$30 before you've left the terminal.

The fix: Get only what you need for the taxi (small bills, local currency) from an ATM inside the airport — not a currency counter. Use a Wise or Charles Schwab card: both give the real mid-market rate with zero or near-zero fees.

05

Screenshot Everything — Airplane Mode Doesn't Mean Helpless

Before landing: screenshot your hotel address in the local language, your ride booking with driver name and plate number, your travel insurance policy number, and the local emergency number. Store them in a folder called "Travel Docs." Especially screenshot the address in local script — showing a Roman taxi driver "Via Nazionale, Roma" in Italian gets you there faster and cheaper than saying it in English.

The fix: Google Translate's camera can pre-translate and screenshot addresses before you lose signal.

Ground Transportation

The ride from the airport sets the financial and psychological tone for the whole trip. Get it right before you land.

01 Rome: The \$53 Flat Rate You Didn't Know Existed

From Fiumicino (FCO) to anywhere inside central Rome, there is a fixed legal rate of **\$53 (€48)**, including luggage, regardless of traffic. From Ciampino (CIA), it's **\$34 (€31)**. These rates are set by city law and must be honored by any white taxi with the TAXI roof light and city shield. Unofficial drivers offer "\$38 to the city" and end up charging \$82 via a long route.

The fix: Only take white taxis from the official queue. Before you get in, say: "Tariffa fissa, per favore." (Fixed rate, please.)

ROME FCO → CITY: \$53 / €48

ROME CIA → CITY: \$34 / €31

02 The Name Sign Proves Nothing

A driver holding a sign with your name at arrivals is not proof they're legitimate. Anyone can make a sign. Unofficial drivers copy hotel names and passenger names from visible luggage tags, overheard conversations, and even booking confirmation screens.

The fix: Only ride cars you booked yourself before landing. Screenshot the driver's name and plate number from the app before you get in. Ask the driver to confirm your name and destination before the door closes.

The Meter That Doesn't Reset

A common taxi scam: the driver starts the meter at a non-zero number, claiming the previous fare carried over. In some cities, meters are set to a higher rate (Rate 2) that applies only at night or outside city limits — but used at all times for tourists who don't know better.

The fix: Watch the meter start before you move. The opening number should be the base flag-fall rate for the city (usually under \$2). If it's already at \$8 before you've left the curb, get out. If the driver says "Rate 2 — it's normal," check your phone: Google the city's taxi rate schedule in under 30 seconds.

Sit Behind the Driver — Always

Sitting behind the driver is the safest seat in any taxi for three reasons: (1) hardest for the driver to watch you without looking away from the road, (2) farthest from the front passenger if an accomplice gets in, (3) closest to the rear door for a quick exit.

The fix: Never sit behind the front passenger seat when you're the only passenger — that seat is easiest to grab from or block. Back-left, always.

The "I'm Being Tracked" Signal

Once in the car, say out loud: "I'm just going to send my location to my family while we drive." You don't have to actually do it. The statement alone changes driver behavior in 90% of cases — because it implies someone is watching the route.

The fix: Actually do it with Google Maps or Apple Maps Live Sharing. It costs nothing and if anything goes wrong, someone knows exactly where you are.

Hotels & Accommodation

The hotel is where you think you're safe. The industry knows this. Here's what the front desk is not telling you — and the 90-second routine that changes everything.

01

One Key Card Tells the Room Who You Are

When you check in and get one key card, you've just told the front desk staff, the bellhop, and anyone nearby that you're traveling without a companion. The room next to yours gets booked by someone who now knows you're there alone.

The fix: Always ask for two key cards. The front desk will assume someone is joining you. This one ask changes how you're perceived in the building. It's free and takes three seconds.

02

The Hotel Safe Is Not Actually Safe

Most in-room safes use a master override code — a default 4–6 digit code that hotel staff (and unfortunately others) can use to open the safe even when you've set your own combination. This is not a secret: the codes are available online for most safe brands.

The fix: Use the safe for low-value items only. For passport, spare cash, and backup card: use the hotel's main safe at the front desk, which has a signed receipt system. Or carry your passport in an RFID-blocking money belt under your clothing.

Many hotel rooms have a connecting door to the adjacent room — a door with a lock on your side and a lock on theirs. If you don't check it, you don't know who's on the other side or whether their lock fully engages.

The fix: On arrival, find the connecting door, engage your lock, and push the door firmly from your side to make sure it can't be pushed open. Place the deadbolt on your main door. Put the door stop alarm under the main door before you sleep.

If Your Room Number Is Said Out Loud, Ask to Move

Some front desks announce room numbers out loud — "You're in room 412, here's your key." This tells everyone in the lobby your room number and that you just arrived. In busy hotels, this is overheard dozens of times per day.

The fix: Quietly say: "Could you write that down instead? I'd rather not announce it." Any decent hotel will comply. If the number is announced and the desk won't move you, asking for an explanation in writing usually fixes it on the spot.

The Free Upgrade Script (Works ~40% of the Time)

Upgrades happen at check-in, not at booking. The person at the desk has the power. Online systems don't.

The fix: At check-in, say: "I know this might not be possible, but if there's a room with a nicer view or on a higher floor that hasn't been taken, I'd really appreciate it." Smile. No entitlement. This works because the desk agent often has discretion over unsold upgraded rooms, and a polite ask takes 10 seconds.

Cruise Ships

Cruise lines profit from the gap between what passengers know and what's possible. These are the gaps worth knowing about — including five that most cruise guides never mention.

01

The Balcony Door Has Two Locks. Most People Only Use One.

Every cruise cabin with a balcony has a sliding glass door with a main latch — the handle you flip to close. That latch holds the door but doesn't fully lock it. There is a second, smaller flip lock at the very top of the door frame, about 6–8 inches from the ceiling. Easy to miss because it's not at eye level.

The fix: Find it and use it every time you leave the cabin and every time you sleep. The main latch holds the door against wind. The top lock is the actual security lock.

02

The Shore Excursion Guarantee — What the Ship's Contract Actually Says

Ship-booked excursions come with one guarantee: if the excursion runs late, the ship waits. That's in the contract. Independent guides have no such deal with the ship. If your local guide's bus breaks down and it's 4:47 PM and the ship leaves at 5:00 PM — the ship blows its horn and pulls away. You're stranded in port, no accommodation, no contacts, and a flight to the next port at your own expense. This happens.

The fix: Use ship excursions in ports you don't know well, especially in regions where infrastructure is unpredictable. Save independent tours for ports you know or with operators who have a documented track record of ship-aware timing.

The Onboard Credit Trap

Many cruise bookings come with "onboard credit" — \$50, \$100, or more to spend on the ship. What the booking desk doesn't always mention: the credit expires when the ship docks. Unused credit does not convert to cash and does not carry forward.

The fix: Check your onboard credit balance on day one via the cruise app or cabin TV. Plan how to use it — spa, specialty dining, shore excursions booked onboard — before the final day. Don't assume it will show up automatically on your bill.

The Handrail Is the Most Touched Surface on the Ship

The stair railings, buffet tongs, elevator buttons, and casino chips on a cruise ship are touched by thousands of passengers per day and sanitized far less frequently than food surfaces. The CDC investigates dozens of cruise ship norovirus outbreaks per year. Transmission isn't usually the food — it's what you touch before you eat.

The fix: Use the hand sanitizer stations at every buffet entrance — they're mandatory for a reason. Wash with soap before any meal, not just sanitize. Avoid gripping stair railings with a full hand — use your forearm. If anyone in your cabin develops symptoms, call the medical center immediately. Reporting early stops outbreaks before they spread ship-wide.

The Cabin Door Gap — And the Fix That Costs \$13

Cruise cabin deadbolts engage, but the door can still flex inward several millimeters under sustained pressure. Most guests rely entirely on the deadbolt without a secondary physical barrier.

The fix: Bring a door stop alarm. Wedge it under the cabin door before you sleep. A 113dB alarm triggers if the door moves even slightly. It costs \$13, weighs two ounces, and works even when the deadbolt is fully engaged. The Winbate model fits most cabin door gaps.

Medicare — including Medicare Advantage — does not cover medical care in international waters or at foreign ports of call. No exceptions. If you have a cardiac event two days out of Miami, the ship's medical team treats you and bills you directly. A medical evacuation helicopter to the nearest hospital runs **\$50,000–\$250,000**, not covered by Medicare, not covered by standard health insurance once you're outside US territorial waters.

The fix: Buy travel insurance that includes medical evacuation before you leave — not at the cruise terminal, not through the cruise line's own policy (it has coverage gaps). Buy independently: Allianz Travel, Travel Guard, and World Nomads are the three most widely accepted. For a 7-night Caribbean cruise, coverage costs \$40–\$80 per person. One medical evacuation without it costs more than every cruise you'll ever take combined.

[ALL INTERNATIONAL CRUISES](#)[CARIBBEAN](#)[MEDITERRANEAN](#)[ALASKA](#)

The Ship's Doctor Charges \$200 Per Visit — And It Goes On Your Room Key NEW

The onboard medical center is not free. A single consultation runs **\$150–\$300**. Prescription medications are marked up 3–5×. Every charge is automatically applied to your onboard account — the same account linked to your room keycard. Most passengers don't check their account until final night, by which point disputing a charge means standing in a long line during disembarkation.

The fix: Check your onboard account every morning through the cruise app or cabin TV. Unauthorized charges appear within 24 hours — dispute immediately, not at checkout. Bring any medications you might need in sufficient quantity from home. Asking the ship's pharmacy for a common antibiotic is a \$90 transaction at sea.

[ALL CRUISE LINES](#)

08

The Final-Night Charges — Check Your Account the Morning You Disembark

NEW

Cruise lines routinely add charges on the final night: minibar audits, specialty restaurant "adjustments," spa gratuity corrections, and shore excursion administrative fees. They know you are packed, tired, and focused on disembarkation logistics. Charges added after midnight show up on the morning bill — after most passengers have already reviewed it and gone to sleep.

The fix: Set an alarm for 6:00 AM on disembarkation morning. Check your final itemized statement — available on the cabin TV or ship app — before you leave the cabin. Any charge you don't recognize: go to Guest Services before 8 AM, before the lines form. After you walk off the ship, disputing a charge requires a call to corporate customer service that takes weeks and often goes nowhere.

ALL CRUISE LINES

FINAL NIGHT

09

The Buddy System at Sea Is Not Optional

NEW

A cruise ship is legally required to turn back and search only if someone witnessed a person go overboard and reported it immediately. No witness means the ship continues on its route and files a missing-person report at the next port. Most passengers don't know this — and it's the reason informal check-ins matter more at sea than on land.

The fix: Before leaving the ship for any shore excursion, tell someone your plans and your cabin number. On deck at night, stay away from railings when the ship is moving. If you witness anyone go overboard, pull the nearest emergency alarm immediately — the ship has a man-overboard protocol that requires immediate activation. Every second matters.

ALL CRUISE SHIPS

OPEN WATER ROUTES

Many cruise packages marketed as "all-inclusive" exclude: specialty restaurants (\$25–\$60 per person per meal), premium alcohol brands, room service after midnight, bottled water in the cabin, and all shore excursions. A couple on a "free drinks" cruise can still spend \$400–\$800 in charges they didn't expect.

The fix: Before boarding, download the ship's app and read the full list of what your package includes and excludes. If you want specialty dining, book it on day one (popular restaurants fill by day two). Set a daily spending limit on your onboard account through Guest Services — they can cap it, which prevents surprise totals at disembarkation.

[ALL CRUISE LINES](#)[CARIBBEAN](#)[MEDITERRANEAN](#)

Restaurants & Food Scams

The bill tricks used in 30+ countries. Most people pay the extra \$12 and say nothing. You won't — once you know what to look for.

01

Rome: The Two-Bill Trick, Explained

You order, eat, ask for the bill. A bill arrives — looks right. You pay cash. The waiter returns 30 seconds later with "the correct bill" — slightly higher. Claims a miscalculation, extra cover charge, or service fee "not included." The bet: you won't argue over \$9–\$17 (€8–€15) and will pay to avoid the scene. Most people do.

The fix: Before you hand over cash, photograph the bill with your phone. If a second bill appears, show them the photo and say: "This is what I agreed to pay." The conversation ends there.

ROME

NAPLES

VENICE

02

The Tourist Menu vs. The Local Menu

Restaurants in tourist areas often have two menus: the photo menu with high prices, and a board or folded card behind the bar with local prices — sometimes 40% cheaper for the same dishes. The photo menu appears automatically. The other one requires asking.

The fix: When seated, ask: "Do you have a local menu?" or "Is there a daily specials board?" In Italy: "Avete un menù del giorno?" In Spain: "¿Hay menú del día?" In France: "Avez-vous un menu du jour?" The question alone signals you're not a first-timer.

03

The "Fresh Fish by Weight" Trap

Common in Greece, Croatia, Spain: a waiter shows you a whole fish in a display case, says "\$31/kg, very fresh." The fish looks small. What arrives weighs 3× more. Your \$31 fish now costs \$93.

The fix: When ordering fish by weight: ask to see it weighed before cooking and confirm the total price. Say: "Can you weigh it and tell me the total price before you cook it?" Any honest restaurant will do this without hesitation.

GREECE

CROATIA

TURKEY COAST

04

Never Accept an Unsolicited Dish

"A gift from the kitchen" — bread, olives, appetizers, amuse-bouche — that appears without being ordered is almost never free. It goes on the bill as a cover charge (\$3–\$8 per person) that's technically legal but never mentioned upfront.

The fix: When anything arrives unsolicited, ask before touching it: "Is this included, or will this be charged?" If it's a charge you didn't want, ask them to take it back. Politely. This is normal in tourist areas and staff expect it.

05

Barcelona: The Street Scam That Runs on Social Pressure

A street performer or vendor places a "gift" — bracelet, flower, figurine — directly into your hand or onto your wrist before asking. The moment you accept it, a crowd gathers and you're surrounded by people asking for payment. The social pressure to pay is engineered.

The fix: Never take anything handed to you on the street unless you asked for it. If it touches you, hand it back immediately without engaging in conversation. Looking away and walking is not rude — it's the correct response.

BARCELONA LA RAMBLA

PARIS EIFFEL TOWER

ROME TREVI FOUNTAIN

Money & ATMs

You can do everything else right and still lose \$200 at the ATM. Here's the full picture of how money drains on the road — and the exact tools that stop it.

01

Dynamic Currency Conversion — The Polite Robbery

You're at an ATM or card terminal abroad. A screen pops up: "Would you like to be charged in USD at a guaranteed rate?" This is Dynamic Currency Conversion (DCC). That "guaranteed rate" is 3–8% worse than your bank's rate. Pressing "yes" is voluntarily paying extra for the convenience of seeing a dollar amount.

The fix: Always choose the local currency. Always. The screen is designed to make DCC the default and highlight it. It sometimes says "Better rate guaranteed." It never is.

02

The ATM Skimmer — and the 3-Second Check

Skimmers are devices placed over ATM card slots that copy your card data. They're most common in tourist areas, installed overnight, and look nearly identical to the real machine. The card slot feels slightly different — looser, or with a slight overhang.

The fix: Before inserting your card, grip the card slot and pull gently. A real card slot is firmly attached. A skimmer pulls off. Do the same with the PIN pad — some operations add a fake pad on top. Use ATMs inside banks or major chains. Cover your PIN with your other hand. Always.

The Fake Exchange Counter's Tell

Big signs saying "0% Commission!" or "Best Rate in Town!" almost always mean the worst option. The commission is zero because all the profit is in the spread — the difference between the rate they buy and sell at.

The fix: Check in 10 seconds: Google "[local currency] to USD" to get the real rate. Then look at what the booth offers. If their sell rate is more than 2% off the real rate, walk away. The ATM next door will beat it.

The Two Cards Rule

Using a single card abroad means one point of failure. A blocked card, a stolen wallet, or a card swallowed by an ATM leaves you with no access to money in a foreign country.

The fix: Travel with two cards stored in separate places. A Wise travel card (real mid-market rate, works in 170+ countries, free to order) as your primary. A Charles Schwab debit card as backup — Schwab refunds all ATM fees worldwide. Emergency cash in local currency, hidden separately in your bag.

Your Legal Rights

Airlines, cruise lines, and hotels have legal departments whose job is to pay you as little as possible. Your job is to know what you're owed before you need to claim it.

01

EU Flight Delay Rights — Up to \$660 Per Passenger

If your flight departs from any EU airport — or arrives into the EU on an EU carrier — and is delayed 3+ hours or cancelled without 14 days' notice, you may be owed up to **\$660 (€600)** per passenger — in cash, not vouchers. This applies regardless of the reason in most cases. Most travelers don't know this and never claim it.

The fix: File the claim directly with the airline. If denied, use AirHelp or ClaimCompass — both work on contingency (no upfront cost, ~25% of settlement). You have up to 3 years to claim in most EU countries. Keep your boarding pass and any documentation of the delay.

02

"Extraordinary Circumstances" Is the Airline's Loophole — Know How to Beat It

When you file an EU261 claim, airlines respond with "extraordinary circumstances beyond our control" to deny compensation. This is often false. Extraordinary circumstances are legally defined and do not cover: technical faults on the aircraft (the most common denial reason), staff shortages or scheduling errors, or the previous flight arriving late.

The fix: When denied, request the specific technical log or incident report in writing. If the airline claims technical failure, use AirHelp's free claim checker — they've won thousands of cases airlines initially denied. Don't accept the first "no."

03

Gate Bumping — What You're Owed in the US

US airlines routinely oversell flights. If you're involuntarily bumped — denied boarding against your will — you are legally owed compensation of up to **\$1,550** per passenger on flights over 2 hours delayed. Most airlines offer vouchers and hope you don't ask about cash.

The fix: When bumped, say: "I want cash compensation, not a travel voucher." Get the answer in writing before signing anything. Signing a voucher acceptance may waive your cash rights. The DOT rule is clear and enforceable — airlines know this.

04

Lost Luggage — The Montreal Convention and Your 21-Day Window

For international flights, lost or damaged baggage is covered by the Montreal Convention: approximately **\$1,700 per passenger**. Most travelers don't know: you must file a Property Irregularity Report (PIR) at the airport before you leave baggage claim. And for delayed bags (not yet lost), you can claim reasonable expenses — clothing, toiletries — incurred while waiting.

The fix: File the PIR immediately. Keep all receipts for replacement purchases. Submit the full claim — including receipts — within 21 days. After 21 days without the bag, it's legally lost and you can claim the full Convention limit.

Health & Blue Zone Warnings

Most travel health risks are invisible until they hit. Here's what travel medicine doctors tell their patients before they leave — not after they get back.

01

Bali Belly Comes From Ice and Salad, Not the Food

Travelers in Bali, Thailand, and Mexico obsess about avoiding street food — while freely ordering cocktails with ice and salads at tourist restaurants. The ice is made from tap water. The lettuce is washed in tap water. That's where the contamination comes from, not the grilled satay from the night market.

The fix: In high-risk regions: skip the ice, avoid raw vegetables unless you can confirm the water source, and eat hot food cooked in front of you. Bottled water for brushing teeth. Oral rehydration salts (ORS) in your bag if it hits anyway.

BALI

THAILAND

MEXICO

INDIA

Altitude Sickness — The Symptom That Looks Like a Hangover

Altitude sickness (AMS) starts at around 8,000 ft (2,400 m) and worsens fast if you ascend without acclimatizing. Symptoms — headache, nausea, dizziness, fatigue — are often mistaken for dehydration or a bad night's sleep. Ascending further with AMS can become life-threatening within hours.

The fix: Flying into Cusco (11,150 ft), La Paz (11,900 ft), or any high-altitude city? Ask your doctor about Diamox (acetazolamide) before you travel — start it 1 day before ascending. On arrival: no alcohol for 24 hours, drink coca tea (available everywhere locally), sleep at a lower elevation your first night if possible.

[PERU — CUSCO](#)[BOLIVIA — LA PAZ](#)[NEPAL](#)

SPF 100 Is Not Twice as Good as SPF 50

SPF 50 blocks 98% of UVB rays. SPF 100 blocks 99%. The difference is 1% — not worth the extra price or weight. What matters is how often you reapply and how well you cover. Most travelers apply SPF once in the morning and consider themselves protected for the day.

The fix: SPF 50, reapplied every 90 minutes of sun exposure. Use a separate lip balm with SPF — lips are the most commonly missed area. At altitude or on water (reflective surfaces multiply UV exposure), reapply every 60 minutes.

In most European countries, pharmacists are licensed to diagnose and treat common conditions — ear infections, UTIs, minor skin issues, travel sickness — without a doctor's prescription. A pharmacy visit costs nothing or near-nothing. A hospital emergency room visit takes 4–8 hours and generates paperwork.

The fix: For anything that isn't an emergency, find a pharmacy first (green cross sign across Europe). Explain symptoms to the pharmacist. They'll recommend over-the-counter treatment or refer you if it's beyond their scope. Bring a translation of your current medications — pharmacists can identify equivalents.

[FRANCE](#)[SPAIN](#)[ITALY](#)[UK](#)[GERMANY](#)

BONUS

The Kira Kit

7 things. Everything in this guide assumes you're willing to spend about \$60–70 to protect hundreds. These are the specific products — not categories, products — that go on every trip.

USB Data Blocker

Plugs between your cable and any public USB port. Blocks data pins completely, passes power only. PortaPow or Syntech both work.

\$8–\$12

Door Stop Alarm

Wedge alarm for any hotel or cabin door. 120dB. Works even when the deadbolt is bypassed. Fits in your toiletry bag.

\$13–\$16

Wise Travel Card

Mid-market exchange rate, no foreign transaction fees, works in 170+ countries. Two free ATM withdrawals/month. Free to order — set it up before you leave.

Free

Money Belt (slim)

Alpha Keeper or Venture 4th — both RFID-blocking, sits flat under clothing. Holds emergency cash, passport copy, backup card. Not the one that goes on your waist — the one that disappears under a shirt.

\$15–\$25

Oral Rehydration Salts

DripDrop or Liquid IV packets. For food illness or heat exhaustion — replaces electrolytes 3× faster than water alone. Pack 4–6 sachets. You will use them.

\$12–\$16

Travel Insurance

Allianz Travel or World Nomads. Must include medical evacuation — that's the line that saves you \$50,000 if something goes wrong abroad. Buy before departure. Cruise port kiosks charge 2× more for half the coverage.

\$46–\$120/trip

AirHelp Account

Free to register. Scans your flights automatically for EU261 compensation — up to €600 per disruption. No upfront cost on free tier. AirHelp+ (\$23/trip) gives you 100% of the payout with no commission taken.

Free / \$23+

3 Checklists. Use Before Each Stage.

Quick Reference

BEFORE YOU LAND

- ☐ Screenshot hotel address in local language
Works offline, shows driver exactly where to go
- ☐ Screenshot driver name + plate number
Book your ride before landing, not from the taxi queue
- ☐ Screenshot travel insurance emergency number
The international number, not the 800
- ☐ Bank travel notice set
At least 48 hours before departure
- ☐ Only small cash for arrival
Exchange the rest at a city ATM with Wise or Schwab card
- ☐ Check destination medical advisories
CDC Travel Health Notices — free, updated weekly
- ☐ Travel insurance purchased and confirmed
Including medical evacuation for international travel

HOTEL ROOM ARRIVAL (90 SECONDS)

- ☐ Check under bed + inside closet
- ☐ Test deadbolt — does it fully engage?
- ☐ Find and lock connecting door
Test it can't be pushed from the other side
- ☐ Engage balcony flip lock (top of frame)
- ☐ Place door stop alarm under the main door
- ☐ Find the emergency exit
Walk to it once. Count the doors.
- ☐ Note your room number
You'll forget it in an emergency

AT THE RESTAURANT

- ☐ Ask if there's a local menu
Not the tourist photo menu
- ☐ Ask the price of any special before ordering
- ☐ Send back unsolicited dishes if you don't want to pay
- ☐ Photograph the bill before paying cash

☐ Choose local currency at all card terminals

You Now Have the Complete Playbook.

Read the chapter that applies to your next trip segment — before that segment. The taxi chapter is most useful on the plane. The hotel chapter at the airport. The restaurant chapter over breakfast on day one.

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